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Title:

In A Jam

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(Alex, an average-looking teen, sits in a bus, talking on the phone.)

Alex: Yeah I'm taking a bus out there now, it should only be… Thirty more minutes? Maybe an hour in bus-time. Don't worry, I'll be there, shooting space-zombies with you in no time. ...I don't know, I think it's the last stop on the route, everyone else got off already. It's just me just sitting here alone, talking like a weirdo in the middle of nowhere. Yeah, duh, alone besides the bus driver--

(The bus stops suddenly.)

Alex: Whoa! Um, excuse me miss? Is something wrong?
Driver: Last stop!
Alex: A-ha, good one. (no response) Um, the last stop is supposed to be Alfredville.
Driver: Yeah maybe on the OLD ROUTE. It changed.
Alex: But I literally looked it up this morning--
Driver: Look, you don't have to go home but you can't stay on this bus! (opens door) Now move it or lose it!
Alex: Uh, I think even if I move it I will lose it. This looks like the middle of nowhere--
Driver: NOW!!!

(The driver grabs Alex, tosses them off the bus. They collect themselves, wiping away dust as the bus drives off.)

Alex: Wow, well that was rude. (looking at his phone) Where even am I? ...Not in Uber-territory apparently. (sees something) What… is. Is that a festival? That's not a mirage, is it? I've heard about those. On the internet.

(Alex walks towards a contained but sizeable little festival jutting out of the desert, a collection of booths with a big grand stage in the middle and a huge, elegant sign marking the 'Harrisontownville 134th Annual Jam-boree'.)

Alex: (reading) The 134th Annual Harrisontownville Jam-boree?

(Alex approaches the nearest booth, worked by a focus-crazed human named Jimble.)
Jimble: (handing out jars) Here's two blueberry for ya, one strawberry...
Alex: Excuse me, do you know where the nearest--
Jimble: DON'T TALK TO ME UNLESS YOU'RE BUYING SOMETHING, THIS IS PRIME JAM-TIME!
Alex: Oh, I'm sorry, I didn't realize that it was jam-time. I was just hoping you could help me find a way home, I got abandoned--
Jimble: Help you? Why would I help you? In the middle of the 134th Annual Harrisontownville Jam-boree?!
Alex: The… the what?
Jimble: Are you dense? Or deaf? Or both?! **The 134th Annual Harrisontownville Jam-boree!**
Alex: Yeah, saying it again isn't going to make me understand. I've just never heard of--
Jimble: You… pfft. You. You have *never* heard of the Harrisontownville Jam-boree?
Alex: Mm nope. Never.
Jimble: Have you heard of anything?
Alex: Yes, I've heard of lots of things.
Jimble: Wow. Where did you just get off the bus from.
Alex. Uh. Sacramento?
Jimble: That wasn't an actual question. Now leave me alone! I've gotta sell twice as fast now if I want any shot at winning the jam-crown.
Alex: Sorry, I'm just trying not to die in the desert, so I thought you might help.
Jimble: Well I need some help! Beating Sandra in this life and death competition.
Alex: Selling jelly is a life and death competition?
Jimble: DOES IT LOOK LIKE I'M JUST USING FRUIT JUICE?! This is jam, ya dingus. We're not afraid of seeds here. We crush that fruit and make the most delicious nectar the gods have ever had. Now leave me alone. Go bother Sandra if you want help.
Alex: No need to raise your voice, but okay. I'll try Sandra, thanks.
Jimble: YOU'RE WELCOME!

(Alex walks over to the next booth and approaches the beauty-pageant star that is Sandra, who's handing jars to customers with a big smile.)
Alex: Uh, hi. Sandra?
Sandra: (to Alex) I'll be with you in just a moment.

Alex: Oh, cool. Thanks. (waits) It's just that I've been stranded here and that person named Jimble said--

Sandra: Jimble said to bother me? He said that he'd help you if you just distracted me for a while to get my sales down? Jimble wants to use you for sabotage? Jimble said that raspberry is the easiest jam to make??

Alex: He said those first three things, yeah basically.

Sandra: Let me tell you something, stranger.

Alex: Alex.

Sandra: Sure. I was born with a silver spoon in my mouth. Do you know what that spoon was filled with?

Alex: Uh, jelly?

Sandra: JAM! ...It was filled with jam. I was a very popular student. Prom queen. I got into Harvard, Yale, University of Phoenix Online. But none of it was enough. The only thing I had a taste for?

Alex: Jam?

Sandra: I was gonna say that.

Alex: I'm sorry.

Sandra: Now you've ruined my whole train of thought, it was a whole speech...

Alex: Look, could you just help me? I'm supposed to be at my brother's place in twenty minutes--

Sandra: Yeah and my husband wants me to help you so I lose.

Alex: Wait. Jimble is your husband?

Sandra: Duh. I've been married to Jimble for twelve great, jam-filled years. He's the light of my life. But on this day… he is my mortal enemy.

Alex: That doesn't sound healthy.

Sandra: Yeah, well. Neither is jam. (to a customer) Oh, no miss--it's full of antioxidants and it's so good for your bones I brush my teeth with it!

Alex: ...So are you going to help me or not?

Sandra: Not today, Satan.

Alex: What?

Sandra: Sorry, too far. I'm just too busy. Maybe Gladiator will help you.

Alex: There's a person here named Gladiator?

Sandra: Oh my god shut up and leave me alone! Sorry.

Alex: Ouch.

Sandra: Too far again.
Alex: Yeah.
Sandra:But seriously go away. Get out of my sight. NOW!
Alex: Wow, okay. Sorry.

(A bit bewildered, Alex walks over to the hulking Gladiator's stand.)
Alex: Hi, uh. Gladiator?
Gladiator: Good day, smaller person! Could I interest you in one of our jams? You seem like a boysenberry human to me…
Alex: Uh, no actually. Thanks. I just got stranded here and no one is helping me. They just wanna sell their jams.
Gladiator: Ah yes. That is the mindset of inferior jam creators. But you have come to the god of jams.
Alex: Oh. Okay, cool--
Gladiator: The jam-god.
Alex: Right.
Gladiator: I have won twelve Harrisontownville Annual Jam-boree's in a row. I have not been defeated since my biceps were under twenty inches wide. And that was a *very* long time ago. (shaking Alex's hand) The name is Gladiator.
Alex: It's nice to meet you, Gladiator. Hey, can I ask you something?
Gladiator: Shoot. Not literally of course, because your bullet will be stopped by my pectoral muscles. Don't want you wasting bullets now.
Alex: Why is everyone here so obsessed with jam? I mean. It almost feels unreal. A random jam festival in the middle of the desert. There are customers, but no cars, or houses, or… I keep wondering if this is like. *Reality*, or maybe I just died in that bus and this is some sort of afterlife purgatory? Is this hell? Was I a bad person that deserves to spend eternity going from jam booth to jam booth trying to find a ride? Is this what the rest of eternity will be?! (phone rings/vibrates) Oh thank god. Hey Jack. No, I'm still alive, I guess. I'm just still trying to find a way out of here...
Gladiator: Fret no more, tiny Alex. I will gladly help you.
Alex: Wait, really? That's awesome. (to phone) Okay, I'm about to get out of here, I'll see you soon. (hangs up) So, I just either need a ride to the nearest town, or if you know someone who can--
Gladiator: Before we ship you out of here, you appear famished.

Alex: Well, I am a bit hungry, but I'd really rather just--
Gladiator: Here. Try some boysenberry jam. I've spread it atop a crostini with brie, as a flavor and textural counterpoint to my award-winning jam.
Alex: Really, I just want to get out of this place--
Gladiator: This is your way out, Alex.
Alex: What?
Gladiator: I will only help you if you try my jam.
Alex: Ha, good one. (off Gladiator's stare) You're joking, right?
Gladiator: I never joke when it comes to jam.
Alex: ...Okay, sure that's fine. As long as you *promise* to help me.
Gladiator: I swear on my deltoids that I will help you. And I never lie when it comes to my deltoids.
Alex: Hm. Okay. (takes a bite) Oh. Oh that is good.
Gladiator: Mmhmm. Yesss.
Alex: This… this is really really good.
Gladiator: Yes it is.
Alex: Wow. Like. I don't think I've ever eaten anything this good.
Gladiator: You haven't.
Alex: I think I'm starting to see why you guys are all so obsessed with jams!
Gladiator: You are.
Alex: Mmm. Can I have some more?
Gladiator: I'm sorry, I can only offer one free sample.
Alex: What? No, come on, Glad, you've got to! That stupid bus took the last of my money and… I need my jam, man!
Gladiator: I know you do. Now if you want more jam you must create it yourself.
Alex: ...You're joking, right?
Gladiator: What did I say about joking about jam?
Alex: No… no. No, no no no no no!!! I died, didn't I? This is my punishment?!
Gladiator: If you died this would be heaven, so no need to freak out…
Alex: This… what do I do with my life now? I can't go back to the real world now that I've tasted this jam. Food will never be the same. You knew this and yet you still did it to me!
Gladiator: As was done to all of us at one point.
Alex: I have to leave. I have to meet my brother. But. But I can't…
Gladiator: And now you understand.

Alex: Oh god. Oh no...

(Flash forward to next year--an elegant host speaks into the mic on stage.)
Host: And the winner of the Harrisontownville 135th Annual Jam-boree is… Wow, we have a new champion, folks! Congratulations to your new Jam-God, Alex Mckinney!
Alex: Yes! Yes! What's up now, Gladiator?! Woo! Woo! Man, I'm so glad I abandoned my old life for this. Totally worth it.